Very very rough draft - 8/11/26

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Title: Language is Power? Or Power is Language?

Core Idea: Language (or broadly, communication) is both a vehicle for power and a manifestation of it.

Background Thought:

My thoughts on violence (lol I recorded a poorly articulated 20 minute video about this for reference) are in perfect parallel with my thoughts on language. The gist is that violence on an individual level exists as a physical manifestation (in a sense communication) of overwhelming internal emotions (oftentimes pain). Language therefore exists as a foil because with similar vocabulary on both the speaking and receiving end, overwhelming sensation can in the end at least in part be communicated.

From my perspective, absolving the mental pain of incommunicable feeling (Epicurean?!) can help absolve the violence that results. So when I consider problems relating to violence, I come from a perspective of examining the pain that is preexisting, the pain that it causes, and the pain that persists afterwards. (I lost my train of thought here, not articulating this too well). Now considering language, I can look at it from 2 perspectives: the one of causing pain and the one of absolving it. So there's now this duality.

Originally I thought the model of violence fit well into most things, but now we can generalize this and say that this model of language encompasses more of the human condition. Give me something and I can try to explain it with this. That has been a personal exercise for me the past few days (observe some interaction empirically, then attempt to categorize / explain it using this new proposed model, and if it doesn't fit — refine the model). I hope literally the bare minimum — that you understand what I'm saying or at least trying to say so we can then engage in a conversation (ahem, using language) about it or about why it's wrong or why some facet of the argument could be improved. Now, without further ado.

Idea 1: Language is a tool of self-extension

Sub idea: self-extension

What do I mean by self-extension? Elaine Scarry (the one person I will be referencing the most for maybe the next 10 months) writes in her book *The Body in Pain* that once one's basic physical needs (no physical pain, if we're being Epicurean) are met, we begin to want to extend ourselves beyond our immediate physical surroundings (aka your room). With language, this eventually becomes civilization.

Self-extension can be mentally (e.g., understanding or being understood by the maximum amount of people), physically (travel), materially, spiritually, anything. I come to the conclusion here that then the goal of our lives is to self-extend (interestingly also in parallel with the Epicurean idea of avoiding pain except here instead of avoiding an absolute negative or evil we are chasing an absolute good, supposedly). This fits everyone's agendas and definitions of success and happiness and fulfillment:

- The scholar defines self-extension as an expansion of one's mental faculties and knowledge. The language used here can be that of English, Spanish, Chinese, Arabic, anything. Or it could be of mathematical symbols and programming languages. The scholar can converse with others or the scholar can converse with the universe and natural laws. Either way, the scholar self-extends. (This reads as bulky to you because I was trying to avoid using the pronoun 'he' as a default replacement but also 'one' doesn't sound too good and 'they' is improper grammar, thanks Shuttleworth)
- The CEO defines self-extension as an accumulation of influence (extension) through wealth and power.
- The traveler defines self-extension as a physical extension.
- The priest defines self-extension as a communication with higher power and infinite expansion of consciousness (okay I am not religious and this is from a secular perspective so correct me if I'm wrong). Communication (language) is with the higher power (whatever that may be in the priest's religion or belief system).
- The lover sees their significant other(s) as a part of themselves — self extension — you experience the world both through your own eyes and through theirs. (Also applies platonically, the romantic version is just what we usually think about)
- Etc. We often ask people, 'what makes you happy?' Maybe we should be asking them if their basic needs are fulfilled, and then beyond that, their definition of self-extension.

And from your definition of self-extension comes your version of self-worth. I digress.

Anyways, if we go back to the point about language, that it can be a tool of self-extension, hopefully this is now evident at least from some of the examples. Or be asked: If one was unable to communicate in any manner with anything, how might one self-extend? The very nature of self-extension requires the idea of something other than the self. And you access ideas, people, things outside of the self through language.

From here, civilization is formed. We who can communicate with each other.

Sub idea: pain as a counterexample

I (copying Scarry for the Nth time) understand pain to be the antithesis to language. Scarry posits that pain undos self-extension, reducing your world back to your immediate physical surroundings. NOTHING ELSE MATTERS! YOU ARE IN PAIN! YOUR MONEY, TRAVELS, AND MATHEMATICAL FORMULAS DO NOT HELP RIGHT NOW. Okay, a tad dramatic. But imagine the last time you had a fever or got severely ill, lying in bed, confined to your room. Ideas from your civilization are usurped by that migraine!

This is all to say that pain reduces one's world and reverses self-extension.

Idea 2: Language is power (what you DO)

Beyond our basic physical needs (to not be in physical pain), we turn to the mental ones (Maslow's hierarchy of needs??!!). Mental pain is under an Epicurean definition evil as well. Language can help prevent / absolve it or cause / intensify it (Idea 2).

e.x. Literally, the more languages you understand, the more PEOPLE you understand (self-

extension). The more you extend in this way, the more powerful you are.

Using another examples to prove my point: Academically, the more vocabulary ("jargon") you learn from different fields, the more people / researchers you can communicate with. Or the more people you've met, the more people you've talked (with language) with, the more people you understand, and you can communicate and empathize better with people you meet in the future because you might have seen similar circumstances.

The "power" in this case can be positive or negative. Positive as healing, negative as inducing pain (kind of self explanatory? Everyone knows words can hurt despite others saying stuff like "sticks and stones break my bones but words will never hurt me").

Here are two cases where this is extremely important (there are more but then it would be never ending):

Pedagogy (what is possible):

(Continuing 8/15 11:41PM cuz you know that feeling when you write something and run out of motivation because you know what the end result will look like and it's good and so you can stop trying because you know it'll be okay, yeah now I have odd motivation and a will to sleep as late as possible even though I'm tired so I will continue)

TEACHERS ARE SOOO IMPORTANT. I've made this point before (thought about this one a lot last month), but school should do 3 things at minimum, teach students:

1. Obviously, academic excellence: how to learn, acquire knowledge, etc. <- this is what we think of school as doing by default

BUT ALSO (THIS PART TIES INTO LANGUAGE HEAVILY):

2. emotional intelligence: how to communicate (erm language?) with others. This is why some people go online and talk about how you can immediately tell if someone is a private school kid in college. Because their (some, not all, don't flame me) emotional intelligence is stunted by only understanding how to communicate with a small, bubbled subset of the population.
3. Moral reasoning: this is especially important for those kids who observe inverted morals at home (abuse <- one form or another of inducing pain). This teaching is done through literally showing kids what is wrong and what is write. I.e. pointing at a photo of embezzlement and labeling it as 'embezzlement' same with abuse/other negative things. Or positive things like 'healthy friendship/relationship.' Horace literally says in Sermones 1.4 that 'dictis formabat' about his dad ("he was SHAPING me with his WORDS"), this is what schools should do.

Politics (what unfortunately happens):

If you observe political speeches, you might see different events being framed with different words / rhetoric (I don't really think I need to provide lengthy examples for people to understand this point, it happens too frequently). For example, torture being framed as not torture. Denying an event of causing pain prevents healing, which causes more pain... (aka obstructing justice). This prevents self-extension because again pain is world-destroying. I'll keep this one short because I hope it's self-explanatory and because I'm lazy.

Idea 3: Conversely, power is language (what you don't HAVE TO DO — negative space)

Some people have a lust for power as their form of self-extension (what gives them self-worth). You can examine someone's language for what they don't have to say to see how powerful they are.

A broad example is the idea of English as the global language. English speakers might expect to go other places and have other people speak English to them (POWER — they aren't the ones forced to learn another language). Piggy backing off of this idea, sometimes a country commits war crimes in another country & the court used to conduct the trials is in the perpetrator's language (POWER — they can manipulate their own vocabulary and such to again, prevent healing).

On an individual level, some people are expected to be understood when giving commands or speaking, and if not, they can simply take actions such as firing the employee, beating their child, expelling the student, etc. (i.e. their privilege of expecting to be understood and not having to explain more shows their power)

Those who do not have to flatter or please others (excess language) have power.

Etc.

FINALLY, THE MODEL APPLIES EVERYWHERE AT LEAST AS FAR AS I CAN TELL, HERE ARE SOME CASES I'VE THOUGHT OF RECENTLY (just like dreams, I probably thought of / saw way more than I remember):

1. Incels (said this in my 20 min rant on violence) in the social media version: taught that language (explicitly, expressing your emotions) doesn't matter and that displays of dominance (violence, pain-inducing) are what matters. Evidently problematic
2. Relationships: why people say communication is key communication is key communication is key. A relationship expects equal footing so you can't try to hold all the power and expect the other person to guess what you're feeling and get mad when they don't and say it's their obligation to.'
    1. Sub point: misunderstandings in dramas lol totally avoidable totally devastating totally dumb
3. Bullying / that one quiet kid / hurt people hurt people: because they are hurt and then told to keep quiet but at some point again that explodes into violence on their own part because they were not taught to deal with or to COMMUNICATE THROUGH LANGUAGE what was happening and their emotions
4. Parenting: the two extremes are parents who don't communicate / talk to their children at all and leave them to their own devices and parents who communicate / control too much. The balance is somewhere in between (think I posted a story about this on my spam sometime before??)
5. Abuse often happens when somebody is hindered from self-extending and instead of dealing with their own problems they choose to prevent others from self-extending (posted a story about this a few days ago)
6. Art (dance, art, writing) — language -> self-extension / healing (art therapy)
7. Ok there's more but I'm tired please also help me poke holes in this model if you have any critiques

What I have taken away from this is that when examining people and institutions I can apply the model and see if there's a plausible explanation for why somebody or some company or some country took a certain action. What type of language were they fed from birth / what type of language are they putting out there to achieve what effect?? Most importantly, what is your own form of self-extension? How have you been causing pain to others whether knowingly or not? How can you fix that with your words?

I always think it's funny when a child has learnt some basic words and then still whines for what they want and the parent says 'Use your words.' It's applicable to not just these children. Use your words!! Look at others' words to understand their worlds!! (What in the post-truth society). Important things are only said once: language is everything :)

End notes: I did minimal research, and this reflection was written with inspiration from Epicurean concepts and the first two chapters of Elaine Scarry's *The Body in Pain*. I thought about this for half a day and started writing at 9PM 8/11 with a headache. If there have already been people who have thought of this or refuted this, I wouldn't know yet. Oh inspiration also from Odekirk because I think in the first class of Intermediate S&D we were asked to define 'language.' So we talked a lot about definitions, and finally he said something about how language is the fabric of society. This subconsciously stuck with me for a very long time. I actually think about it quite often.

Also I larp as like 'oh I write with language as simple as possible so everyone can understand it #Epicurean #tenet3:clearlanguage' but no it's just because I'm stupid and don't have fancy words off the top of my head. Also it doesn't even make any sense I'm not reading over it ever again unless someone responds to a certain thing and I forgot what it was lol

Further Reading that might provide more food for thought about this topic (I haven't even read it yet lol): The Body Keeps the Score (Bessel van der Kolk)

Finally unrelated but I would like to share (again I am still working on this visual model as well) what I visualize a person to be physically:

- ok piggy back off of the blank slate idea except we are all squishy toys that are very sticky on the outside and as you go through life you stick to objects / dust in your path and you have these ideas/thoughts/personality traits/etc. stuck to you (over time some can fall off — but old habits die hard the longer something is stuck on there the longer it takes to get it off). And at some point there runs out of space so for some periods of time you just stop acquiring new things (why we see some old people just being stuck in their ways)
- But I was thinking, this doesn't account for the capacity to grow. So turn this squishy into a growing ball that expands so there's more surface area for somebody to have stuff stick to. At some points you stop growing, rates of growth can change over time, etc. (this now accounts for time)
- BUT that doesn't account for the idea of inside v.s. Outside so what you fill yourself with and

what you show to others?

- I thought of a version where every stage of your life you are a sticky ball coated with different things you pick up and then there grows a shell over that that picks up new things and it's harder to get rid of things stuck to you from earlier times, you have to literally burst your own bubble and poke a hole and reach and dig inside of yourself (your own ball) to take it out. But this is not an ideal model to me because what dictates when a new shell is grown?? I'm not really sure
- The most ideal model i can come up with right now is the new-shell-every-arbitrary-increment-of-time ball but you can change what the outermost layer looks like so change the colors of the things there, make some disappear, make some bigger than others (hide certain qualities with others), etc.

What do you think,
Demi Z @ 12:39AM 8/16/26